

ASUS Xonar U1 Audio Station

A Soundcard And Amplifier In One?

The ASUS Xonar U1 looks like a fancy external controller for your speaker but it is a full fledged external soundcard—an external version of the Xonar series of sound cards.

The design is really neat and solid. It's a smooth finish with a port for a microphone and one for headphones or speakers. It connects via USB, and setting it up is simple after you install all the drivers. The top of the Xonar U1 rotates freely and endlessly and is used to control the volume. Pushing the dome down toggles the muting.

The Xonar performs well and provides a very neutral tone without emphasis on

any particular frequency ranges. The player also has a built-in amplifier that also does a good job.

Things can get pretty loud and the volume control must be used with care. There is no clearly audible hissing. There is an array microphone supplied with the player. The drivers and the software bundled are simple and light on system resources. There are features for surround sound effects built into the software.

There are a few shortcomings with the external Xonar U1. First and the most obvious one is the lack of support for anything more than 2.1. This means you have to use this mainly for

music playback. The USB cable is also quite short.

The ASUS Xonar U1 is a decent improvement over the integrated sound solutions found on motherboards. Being compact and also because of the USB connectivity, it can be used with laptops and carried around very easily. With a decent amplifier built into it, it can also be used to drive high-end headphones. A Rs 4,140 tag makes it a good option for those who want quality music. Movie buffs wanting quality surround sound and gaming experience will have

to opt for dedicated PCI-based sound cards.

Specifications

Analog/Digital Combo out, Stereo mic/line-in, Bundled array mic

Contact

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Web site: www.asus.in

Price: Rs 4,140

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



HTC Touch Diamond

Not So Precious

If HTC's *Touch* didn't win you over with its *iPhone* rip-off touch interface that was quirky at best, you can have another go at finger swiping with the Touch Diamond. If the touch interface was really all that productive we wonder why the extra menu keys like Home, Back, and call accept/reject have made their way into this device.

Its very well built, very slim, and compact for a WM device. This is a truly pocketable PDA, though the lack of a keypad does hamper any sort of serious productivity. The screen sports an ultra high resolution



of 480x640 pixels and the result is a very, very crisp display—colours are excellent, much better than any WM device we've used before, and text quality and readability is amazing. The 3D touch interface lags severely, a faster processor (maybe a dual core) and more memory is needed.

Its packed to the gills with software and applications. There's inbuilt GPS with Google Maps pre-installed, Voice Commander, a UTube video viewer, an MP3 editing software, Adobe Flash and Adobe Reader LE as well as the

Opera Browser inbuilt. Incidentally, the Touch Diamond has no memory expansion—4 GB of inbuilt flash has been provided.

Although this device works well as a touch only device—HTCs effort at implementing any kind of gesture sensor doesn't seem to work as well as Apple's touch interface. In terms of pure interaction the *Diamond* will always fail when compared to the *iPhone*. What really works for this device, is its compact dimensions, and the fact that it's a full fledged PDA, (minus keypad). A good bundle of utilities are never bad.

It's not revolutionarily different, but it is different enough from most PDAs to create its very own little niche away from the competing crowd. If you want a WM based device that's sleek, aesthetic, and reasonably usable the Touch Diamond is very suitable,

and perhaps the only choice. If you want a PDA for a lot of office work and mailing then skip this. For Rs 27,990, the HTC Touch Diamond is admittedly expensive, perhaps prohibitively so. If it appeals to you, wait for the price to fall.

Specifications

CPU—528 MHz Qualcomm, RAM—192 MB, ROM—256 MB, 4 GB memory built-in, GPS, 3.2 MP camera, WM 6.1 Pro, 110 grams

Contact

Phone: 9310746555 / 9350263618

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Site: http://www.htc.com/in

Price: Rs 27,990

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Sennheiser PXC 450

Shhhh!—I'm Listening

The PXC 450 belongs to Sennheisers *active* noise cancellation series. The PXC 450 is very well built, and looks nearly identical to the PXC 350—which we reviewed some time ago. The headband has been given a slight boost in padding material, once again the ear cup material is pure leather—making its pedigree evident. The steel headband makes for a really fit tight over ones head. Due to this sound isolation is very good—even with the noise cancellation (NC hereon) switched off. There's a neat talk through button that momentarily disables NC, (till you press the button again). This allows one to hear outside sounds like someone calling you, without actually removing the headphones. The earcups can also be rotated and folded inward, to allow packing and transportation



without risk of damage. The NC part of the headphone is powered by a single cell AAA battery, although the headphone functions normally without the battery since only the active NC circuitry requires juice.

We tried these headphones with our test PC on an X-Fi Platinum soundcard, and on an iPod Touch for a portable set up. To be quite honest the PXC 450 sounds nowhere near its best on a system without proper amplification. We tried them with a headphone amplifier and the difference was startling. Without amplification bass sounds rather boomy and uncussed while the mids are completely recessed,

although detailing is present. The highs are absolutely muddled, and instrument separation is guess work at best. Amping these headphones does the trick—bass becomes clear, hard hitting and much more precise. The mids are more revealing, and the highs lose that muddy effect. Instrument detailing is accurate. However these aren't in the league of Sennheisers own HD600 and HD650, AKGs K701, or BeyerDynamics DT880, which are true audiophile cans.

At Rs 16,990, the PXC 450 is slightly overpriced, although to be quite fair you do get a lot of headphone for the price. It's also not quite a

pure audiophile headphone. Its biggest feature—active noise isolation, works well, but these headphones isolate noise well with NC off as well. Then there's the issue with amplification—another investment, which leads to other investments, as you try to clean up your sound source (since amplification of poor quality signals leads to discernable noise). If only they didn't need a dedicated amplifier, and sounded even 10 per cent better, we'd heartily recommend them.

Specifications

Closed circumaural type headphones, Active Noise Cancellation

Contact

Phone: 95124-4187800

E-mail: info@sennheiserindia.com

Web site: www.sennheiser.com

Price: Rs 16,990

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

Razer Mako 2.1

Fanciful And That's It

The Mako 2.1 are the Razer branded speakers designed for gamers. The design is fresh and unique. Both the satellites and the woofer have a dome style design and they have been built well. A flashy lit-up touch-enabled remote also comes with the speaker set. The source can be connected through a 3.5mm jack or using RCA connectors. The remote also has a Line-in and a headphone out connector built into it.

The performance gets better as time goes by, but there's one important factor—it still doesn't sound powerful enough. The quality

too improves and overall it is pretty satisfactory. The bass is rather shallow and only a few regions of the low frequencies are generated really well.

There are no signs of sound cracking anywhere because the volume doesn't up all that much. The highs are bright, and though the bass isn't loud, it's quite tight. It sounds great—there's nothing special it does with movies, but it sounds good in fast action games.

The remote's touch feature doesn't work very well,

and we had to struggle to set the volume to the maximum. Other than volume, there is an option to adjust the amount of bass. Users can have two inputs connected to the speakers and switch between the two through the remote. The second Line-in is through RCA connectors. The satellites sound a little brighter and less muddy if turned upwards.

As a set of speakers for everyday use with a bit of style element thrown in, the Razer Mako 2.1's are fine.

Rs 22,355 is extremely expensive for 2.1 speakers. Stylish they may be, but there are better performing audiophile and desktop speakers available.

Specifications

3.5mm and auxiliary inputs, Frequency range - 25 - 20,000Hz. Power: 300W RMS

Contact

Phone: 022-40053901

E-mail: enquiry@

netplacetechnologies.com

Price: Rs 22,355

RATINGS	
Features	★★★★★
Performance	★★★★★
Build quality	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

